HOMILY FOR THE 95TH BIRTHDAY OF MOST REV. DR. ANTHONY OKONKWO GBUJI

Readings: Sirach 50:22–24; Philippians 4:4–9; Luke 17:11–19

Gbuji's 95th birthday

Your Excellency, Most Rev. C.V.C Onaga, Catholic Bishop of Enugu,

Your Excellency, Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji, Emeritus Bishop of Enugu, our Chief celebrant and the arrow head of this occasion, a man of many parts,

Your Graces, Your Lordships,

Very Rev. Fr Edwin Omoregbe, the President of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria,

Rev. Frs, Men and Women Religious,

Revered members of the Canon Law Society of Nigeira,

Brothers and Sisters in the Lord,

May the name of the Lord be praised, both now and Forever!

The theme of our reflection comes from Psalm 138:1-3 " I thank you Lord for your faithfulness and Love". This psalm must be ringing like bell in the heart of our Chief Celebrant, Most Rev. Anthony Okonkwo Gbuji as he celebrates 95 solid years of existence in this planet earth. When he celebrated 90 years of age, I remember asking him, 'My Lord, how does it feel to be 90? He answered me, '000 You don't even know when the hours are ticking, the days are passing, the months are going and the years are fleeing. One just needs to be busy doing the right things. Bishop Gbuji is one whom we all know as one who occupies his mind with useful thoughts, reading, dialoguing, teaching or praying.

It is a moment to give thanks to God for His faithfulness and Love. The readings of today spell this theme out very generously. The first reading from Sirarch 50:22) Bless the Lord who has done wondrous things on the Earth; who fosters people's growth right from their mother's womb. The psalmist in Psalm 138 1-3 says, 'I thank you Lord for your faithfulness and Love'. In the second reading, St Paul in Phil 4:4: ´What I want is your happiness´. The Gospel taken from Lk 17:15 says 'And one of them realizing that he has been healed, retured, glorifying God in a loud voice, and he fell at the feet of Jesus and thanked him

My dear brothers and sisters in Christ,

Bishop Gbuji´ 95th Birthday is a celebration of GRACE. Ninety-five years of life! More than six decades of priestly ministry! Over half a century of episcopal ministry! These are reasons to pause, reflect, and give thanks to God. We are grateful to God, not just because God has given him the gift of longevity but more so that God has used him all these years as a worthy instrument to touch people's lives, to strengthen people's faith, to nurture vocations and leave a lasting legacy for generations to come.

In the Gospel pericope, ten lepers cry out to Jesus from a distance. He tells them to go and show themselves to the priests, and as they go, they are cleansed. All ten receive the same gift. But only one stops. He turns around, praising God in a loud voice, and falls at the feet of Jesus, giving thanks. And Luke adds a quiet, piercing detail: he was a Samaritan, a stranger, the one from whom nobody expected anything. Jesus asks, “Were not ten made clean? Where are the other nine?”

Notice what happens next. Ten were cleansed, but to the one who returned Jesus says, “Your faith has saved you.” The nine received a healing. But only the one who returned in thanksgiving received salvation. The difference is gratitude. Thanksgiving is the place where a gift stops being merely something we have and becomes a relationship with the One who gave it. It is no accident that the Church calls her greatest prayer the Eucharist, which means thanksgiving. Every Mass is the Samaritan’s return: we come back to the feet of Jesus, with all that he has done for us, and we give thanks.

Various speakers and writers have described Bishop Gbuji using different titles. In this brief homily, I will reflect on his life through three themes:

1. A life of faith and courage
2. A heart for the Church
3. The man who saw tomorrow

1. A Life of Faith and Courage

Bishop Gbuji’s life and ministry is a true testament to this important Christian virtue of Faith . Of course, these 95 years would not have come without challenges and uncertainties. However, his episcopal motto, *Ad Iesum per Mariam* (to Jesus through Mary) offers us a key to understanding how he managed through these times of joys and sorrows. He has this faithful and trusting relationship with Jesus and a colorful devotion to the Blessed Virgin Mary, the mother of sorrows. All through his life he followed Christ on the way of the cross, in the company of his Blessed Mother, with faith and courage. Bishop Gbuji llived a life of total TRUST IN PROVIDENCE. He never owned a personal bank account but rather lived on whatever the Diocese provides for him.

He lived through colonial administration, Independence, Military Rule, Civil War, political transitions and enormous social transformations. As a young priest and seasoned canonist, he

moved from accompanying the faithful in a small mission station in Fugar, to accompanying refugees when the war broke out in 1967 and working to safeguard and rebuilding the citadels of learning like St. Thomas Teachers' training college Ibusa and other schools. Within these times, he was exposed to numerous risks, but he drew his strength from the cross of the Lord.

In 1973, he became the first bishop of Issele-Uku, a young diocese with few priests and growing faith. He undertook the demanding work of helping to establish this young diocese. For eight months, the Bishop lived in a classroom while his house was being built. But from that classroom came St. Felix Minor Seminary, the Emmaus School of Evangelization, a girls juniorate, hospitals, schools, old peoples' home, a generation of trained Catechists, etc.

In 1996 the church assigned him to take over the leadership of Enugu Diocese with her peculiar situation at the time. His Lordship took courageous steps in steering the ship of the diocese. In fact, it will be fair enough to say that he encountered the height of his episcopal ministry within the 13 years served in Enugu. Bishop Gbuji brought with him what one might call a canonical order to Enugu Diocese; creating more deaneries and parishes. One thing I know about him is that he is never afraid to engage in any worthwhile venture no matter the challenges that lie ahead. He took bold steps to build an UNUM PRESBYTERIUM in Enugu Diocese. .

2. A Heart for the Church (MENS ECCLESIA)

The second dimension of Bishop Gbuji's life is his heart for the Church. The story of the ten lepers teaches that gratitude is more than good manners: it is the recognition that we belong to one another, and that the gifts we receive are meant to deepen our relationship with God and neighbour. Bishop Gbuji's whole being has been dedicated to the good of the Church and the spread of the Gospel. He is rightly described as a true son of God and of the Church, one who has the *mens Ecclesiae* (the mind of the Church).

His background is deeply rooted in the Church. He was born as his mother approached the entrance of a church, raised by a Catechist father and a very pious mother, and formed by saintly priests like Frs Abraham Ojefua and Paul Emechete. Here he likely first learned his love for God and commitment to the Church.

He gave his time, energy and resources to Pope John Paul II's call for a New Evangelization, and every enterprise he began aimed at bringing people to Christ in ways suited to our times: the Emmaus School of Evangelization, the New Evangelization Sisters, St. Paul's International

Institute of Evangelization, St. Bernard Seminary Hostel, and the New Evangelization Research and Ministry (NERAM), among others.

Since retirement, he has continued to seek better ways of drawing people closer to Christ and forming the faithful, devoting himself to the Rite of Christian Initiation of Adults, Small Christian Communities, deepening of faith, preparation of couples for marriage, pastoral care of families, healing of marriages, and social media in the service of evangelization.

He does not initiate these works casually; he undertakes deep academic research to sustain them. At 95, he still sits down to read and write for the cause of evangelization. His writings, lectures and conferences will remain a reservoir from which younger generations can learn.

His life challenges us all, especially Canon Lawyers. It asks every member of this Society: How can our knowledge serve the Church better? How can our expertise promote unity rather than division? How can the law remain a servant of ecclesial communion and mission?

3. The Man who Saw Tomorrow

In one of my articles about our patriarch, I described Bishop Gbuji as the man who saw tomorrow, a shepherd who looked beyond his own time and understood that the future of the Church depends on the decisions we make today. The Fathers of the Second Vatican Council urged the Church to read the signs of the times (Gaudium et Spes, 4). Bishop Gbuji did precisely that: he read the signs of his day with the eyes of tomorrow.

When he came to Enugu, he met a flourishing vocation, he did not see the growing number of candidates as a problem but as a blessing that demanded a response. Remembering the Lord's words, "The harvest is plentiful, but the labourers are few" (Lk 10:2), he laid the foundation of St. Bernard Seminary Hostel, Nchatancha-Nike, to provide an environment where human, spiritual, and pastoral formation could flourish alongside academic studies.

In addition to the New Evangelization Sisters which he founded in Iselle Ukwu, Bishop Gbuji ´s vision extended to full blown evangelization programme. He founded the Emmaus School of Evangelisation, established the St. Paul Institute of Evangelization, and pursued his dream of an integrated academic family through Godfrey Okoye University, which has become a significant contribution to Catholic education in Nigeria.

Indeed, Bishop Gbuji served faithfully in the present while preparing the Church for the future. His legacy reminds us that leadership is not measured only by what we accomplish today, but also by what we prepare for generations yet unborn.

To crown it all, on 13 March 1985, forty-one years ago, Bishop Gbuji played a founding part in establishing the Canon Law Society of Nigeria. He perceived the needs of the Church in Nigeria at a critical moment in her history and seized the opportunity presented by the promulgation of the1983 Code of Canon Law to establish a canonical structure that has since grown into a formidable force in the service and governance of the Church. Thus, he committed himself to creating an institution, an association of canonists, that could carry the work forward beyond any single lifetime. Today the society is having her 38th convention. Who would have thought that the little mustard seed that was planted many years ago would grow to this stature.

The life of our Father therefore challenges all of us, especially those entrusted with leadership: Are we merely meeting the needs of our own time, or are we laying foundations upon which future generations can build? Our political leaders, too, must learn this lesson by pursuing policies that move our society from consumerism to productivity, from dependence to self-reliance, and from short-term gain to lasting development.

Bishop Gbuji saw tomorrow because he understood his responsibility today. May his example inspire us to build not merely for ourselves, but for the generations that will come after us.

Your Lordship, Bishop Gbuji, we thank God for you. We thank him for your years, for your example, and for the society you helped to give the Church in Nigeria

May the God who fosters our growth from the womb continue to deal with you according to his mercy. May the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, guard your heart and mind in Christ Jesus. And may you hear, as the Samaritan heard, the words that sum up a faithful life: “Rise and go; your faith has saved you.” Ad multos annos! Amen.